Rudy Giuliani: “There’s only three things he mentions in a sentence: a noun, a verb, and 9/11.”)

Reports of the Netanyahus’ personal corruption also fueled the perception that he was indifferent to the economic concerns of regular Israelis. A separate comptroller’s report, also released in February, found that the first couple’s expenses at the official residence were beyond “proportionality and reason”. The Netanyahus had spent two-and-a-half times the amount budgeted for hairstylists and makeup, and tens of thousands of shekels to clean their private home in Caesarea, where they spend only a few days each month. (Police would eventually question the prime minister’s wife Sara about suspicions that she had stolen patio furniture, among other things.)

“Trust me, I know what happens next. They’ll start buying golden toilets,” an Iraqi Jew in southern Israel told me. The allusion to Saddam Hussein was only half in jest.

It wasn’t only economics that divided the Israeli electorate—it was also dueling views about Israel’s place in the world. On the campaign trail, center-left voters fretted about Israel’s deteriorating image in Europe and the United States, and its growing religiosity. “I can’t travel abroad without feeling embarrassed,” one woman told me.

The right feared the opposite, that Israel was too deferential to world powers, and that the judiciary had blocked the Knesset from imposing religious and nationalist legislation. “The State Department is breathing down our necks,” a man complained at a Jerusalem campaign event for Bennett’s party.

Is Israel Jewish, democratic, or both? Is the Palestinian minority equal to the Jewish majority, or is it a dangerous fifth column? Should Israel patch up its relations with the West, or go it alone? Netanyahu could not answer these questions; indeed, he didn’t even try. He barely even ran a campaign, appearing only with pre-selected audiences of sympathetic Likud activists. He spoke only about Iran and security matters.

“The debate has gained a new feature, which I would say is universal values, the way Israel is connected to the world,” Tamar Hermann, the polling director at the non-partisan Israel Democracy Institute, said in the run-up to the vote. “Is it important for Israel to be part of the democratic, liberal world? Or should it look for its identity in Jewish morality? It’s not about specific issues, but about which kind of society we want to see.”